SOUTH INDIAN COLLECTION

NO. 06



TAMIL NADU ORIGIN

Puliyodarai

Tangy Tamarind Rice

Temple Prasadam and Travel Food, Perfected

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Puliyodarai

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Puliyodarai

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Rice That Keeps for Days

Puliyodarai — known as puliogare in Karnataka and by other regional names across South India — holds a special dual identity: it's simultaneously one of the most common offerings at South Indian temples, distributed as prasadam to devotees, and one of the most practical foods for long travel, prized for staying fresh and flavorful for days without refrigeration thanks to tamarind's natural preservative qualities.

The dish's defining element is puli kachal, a thick, intensely flavored tamarind paste cooked down with a specific roasted spice blend, jaggery, and sesame oil until deeply concentrated — this paste can be made in large batches and stored for weeks, then mixed with freshly cooked rice whenever needed, which is precisely why puliyodarai has become such reliable travel and temple food across generations.

Nearly every South Indian temple has its own specific version, with subtle variations in spice blend and sweetness that devotees often develop strong loyalty to, treating a temple's particular puliyodarai as inseparable from the spiritual experience of visiting that specific place — a rare case of a food's exact regional and even institutional variation carrying genuine emotional and religious weight.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Rice That Keeps for Days, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

One of the most common prasadam (temple food offering) dishes across South Indian temples, with many temples known for their own distinct version. Valued as reliable travel food, thanks to tamarind's natural preservative qualities keeping the dish fresh for days without refrigeration. The core tamarind paste (puli kachal) can be made in large batches and stored for weeks, mixed fresh with rice as needed. Devotees often develop strong attachment to a specific temple's puliyodarai, treating it as part of that place's spiritual identity.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

20m	30m	6	Med
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Small pan, for roasting spices
- Spice grinder
- Wide pan, for cooking the tamarind paste
- Fine sieve, for straining tamarind pulp

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

The tamarind paste keeps refrigerated for up to a month, or frozen for several months, making batch preparation genuinely practical. Mixed puliyodarai rice keeps at room temperature for a day and refrigerated for up to 3 days — it's specifically known for staying fresh longer than most rice dishes.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the tamarind paste (puli kachal)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Tamarind, seedless	½ cup	80 g	large lemon-size ball
Water	1 cup	240 ml	1 katori
Sesame oil	4 tbsp	60 ml	4 chammach
Dried red chilies	4	4	4
Coriander seeds	1 tbsp	6 g	1 chammach
Chana dal	1 tbsp	12 g	1 chammach
Urad dal	1 tbsp	10 g	1 chammach
Fenugreek seeds	¼ tsp	1 g	¼ chammach
Sesame seeds	1 tbsp	10 g	1 chammach
Jaggery	2 tbsp	25 g	2 tbsp
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

For the tempering & rice

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Rice, cooked and cooled	3 cups	500 g cooked	3 katori
Sesame oil	2 tbsp	30 ml	2 chammach

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For the tempering & rice (cont.)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Mustard seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Peanuts, raw	3 tbsp	30 g	3 chammach
Curry leaves	2 sprigs	15–20 leaves	2 sprigs
Asafoetida (hing)	pinch	pinch	chutki bhar

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Sesame oil (gingelly oil) is traditional and important to authentic flavor, though a neutral oil can substitute if unavailable. This dish's tamarind paste can also be replaced with a good quality store-bought "puliyodarai paste" or "puli kachal," sold by South Indian brands, if making it from scratch feels daunting for a first attempt.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Making the Tamarind Paste

01 EXTRACT THE TAMARIND PULP

Soak the tamarind in warm water for 20 minutes, then squeeze and strain through a sieve to extract a thick, pulpy liquid.

02 ROAST AND GRIND THE SPICES

Dry roast the dried chilies, coriander seeds, chana dal, urad dal, fenugreek seeds, and sesame seeds until fragrant and golden, about 3–4 minutes. Cool and grind to a fine powder.



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Making the Tamarind Paste, continued

03 COOK THE PASTE

Heat sesame oil in a wide pan and add the tamarind pulp, ground spice powder, jaggery, turmeric, and salt. Simmer on low heat for 15–20 minutes, stirring frequently, until thick, dark, and glossy.

Chef tip. the paste should be thick enough to hold its shape on a spoon — this concentrated intensity is what allows a small amount to flavor a large quantity of rice.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The tamarind paste is ready when it's dark brown, thick, and glossy, with the raw tamarind smell completely cooked out, replaced by a deep, rounded aroma.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Assembling the Rice

04 TEMPER THE SPICES

Heat sesame oil in a wide pan and add mustard seeds, letting them pop. Add peanuts, frying until golden, then curry leaves and asafoetida.

05 ADD THE TAMARIND PASTE

Add the tamarind paste to the tempering, stirring to combine with the oil.

06 FOLD IN THE RICE

Add the cooled, cooked rice and toss gently but thoroughly, until every grain is evenly coated in the dark tamarind paste.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Assembling the Rice, continued



Texture indicator. puliyodarai should have deeply colored, separate grains, with the tangy, spiced paste evenly distributed rather than clumped in spots.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Using warm or freshly cooked rice, rather than cooled rice, causes the grains to clump and turn mushy when mixed with the paste. Always start with cooled, ideally day-old rice.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Distributed as prasadam at South Indian temples, often served on a small banana leaf square.
- Packed for long train journeys and travel, valued for staying fresh for days.

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How to serve, continued

Family Style

- A satisfying meal on its own, or alongside a simple side like papad or potato chips.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Paste Right

- A slow, patient simmer when cooking the tamarind paste is essential — rushing leaves a raw, overly sharp tamarind taste.
- Sesame oil isn't just a cooking medium here — its distinct flavor is part of the dish's signature character.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The tamarind paste is the ultimate make-ahead component, keeping for weeks refrigerated or months frozen.
- Make a large batch of paste during a free weekend, then mix fresh rice into it throughout the following weeks for quick meals.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some temple kitchens add a small amount of roasted, crushed peanuts directly into the tamarind paste itself, rather than only in the tempering, for extra texture throughout the dish.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

290 kcal	6 g	44 g	10 g	3 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Gluten, Peanuts, Mustard, Sesame. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Puliogare	the Karnataka name and style for this dish, sometimes with a slightly different spice blend.
Temple-Style Puliyodarai	many South Indian temples have their own distinct, closely guarded version.
Sweet Puliyodarai	some regional versions lean sweeter, with more jaggery than the standard recipe.

Can I make the paste less spicy?

Yes — reduce the number of dried red chilies in the spice blend to taste.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

How long does the tamarind paste really keep?

Refrigerated in an airtight container, it keeps for about a month; frozen, it keeps for several months, making batch preparation very worthwhile.

Is puliyodarai the same as lemon rice?

No — while both are tempered rice dishes designed for travel and temple offerings, puliyodarai uses a tamarind-based paste for a deeper, tangier flavor, while lemon rice relies on fresh lemon juice for a brighter, lighter tang.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Puli Kachal	the concentrated tamarind paste at the heart of this dish, also called puli kachal.
Puliogare	the Karnataka name for this same dish, tamarind rice.
Prasadam	food offered to deities in Hindu temples, then distributed to devotees.
Gingelly Oil	another name for sesame oil, traditional to this dish's flavor.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Puliyodarai

20m	30m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
6	Med
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

TAMARIND PASTE (PULI KACHAL)

Tamarind	80 g
Water	240 ml
Sesame oil	60 ml
Dried red chilies	4
Coriander seeds	6 g
Chana dal	12 g
Urad dal	10 g
Fenugreek seeds	1 g
Sesame seeds	10 g
Jaggery	25 g
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Salt	6 g

TEMPERING & RICE

Rice	500 g cooked
Sesame oil	30 ml
Mustard seeds	4 g
Peanuts	30 g
Curry leaves	15–20 leaves
Asafoetida	pinch

METHOD

01 **Extract the tamarind pulp.** Soak the tamarind in warm water for 20 minutes, then squeeze and strain through a sieve to extract a thick, pulpy liquid.

02 **Roast and grind the spices.** Dry roast the dried chilies, coriander seeds, chana dal, urad dal, fenugreek seeds, and sesame seeds until fragrant and golden, about 3–4 minutes.

03 **Cook the paste.** Heat sesame oil in a wide pan and add the tamarind pulp, ground spice powder, jaggery, turmeric, and salt.

04 **Temper the spices.** Heat sesame oil in a wide pan and add mustard seeds, letting them pop.

05 **Add the tamarind paste.** Add the tamarind paste to the tempering, stirring to combine with the oil.

06 **Fold in the rice.** Add the cooled, cooked rice and toss gently but thoroughly, until every grain is evenly coated in the dark tamarind paste.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Tamarind	80 g	☐ Sesame oil	see recipe
☐ Dried red chilies	4	☐ Coriander seeds	6 g
☐ Chana dal	12 g	☐ Urad dal	10 g
☐ Fenugreek seeds	1 g	☐ Sesame seeds	10 g
☐ Jaggery	25 g	☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g
☐ Salt	6 g	☐ Rice	500 g cooked
☐ Mustard seeds	4 g	☐ Peanuts	30 g
☐ Curry leaves	15–20 leaves	☐ Asafoetida	pinch

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